SYCOPHANCY STORM



BJP leader and Maharashtra minister for skill development **Mangal Prabhat Lodha**, has set off political tremors within the ruling Mahayuti alliance with his remark that CM Devendra Fadnavis not only steers the BJP's affairs but also that "of other parties" in the state. The statement left allies Shiv Sena (Shinde) and the NCP distinctly displeased and has given fresh ammunition to the Opposition. Within the BJP too, there's been some talk, with some leaders privately dismissing it as sycophancy of the highest order.

The Hindi Heat



At a Gita recital in Kolkata on December 7, West Bengal governor **C.V. Ananda Bose** described Hindi as India's "national language", with English playing the "midwife". The problem: India has no national language, only 'official ones', a fact the Constitution makes clear. The comment, coming in linguistically assertive Bengal, was bound to trigger reactions. The ruling Trinamool Congress bristled at what they saw as yet another tone-deaf assertion of Hindi primacy. The guv may have been reaching for a metaphor, but with the strained Centre-state ties, such remarks land less as cultural commentary and more as political provocation.

WATCH OUT...





When Karnataka CM **Siddaramaiah** and deputy **D.K. Shivakumar** met for a public breakfast earlier this month to "clear the air", what instead caught the eye of the Opposition were the Cartier watches both were wearing. Given the Sidda controversy in the past over a Hublot watch (which he was ultimately forced to surrender), it was DKS's turn to face barbs from the BJP, which produced an affidavit claiming he had not declared it among his assets. But a combative DKS posted his latest affidavit on X, which listed a Rolex and two Cartiers, respectively.

By Kaushik Deka, Jumana Shah, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Ajay Sukumaran

ECO WATCH

A HIMALAYAN MYSTERY
TIGER IN THE GLACIERS

By **Jumana Shah**

A team of scientists monitoring the elusive snow leopard were going through camera trap pictures from the Sunderdhunga Glacier Valley in Bageshwar district, in the Kumaon Himalayas, when they were left stunned. For one the images was of a Bengal tiger, the first sighting of the big cat in the region, and what's more at a height of 9,875 feet.



The sighting is a huge surprise as the Bengal tiger is typically associated with lowland forests, plains or foothill jungles, and is seldom found in alpine or sub-alpine terrain. Most historic populations inhabit areas below 6,000 feet. This though is not the highest ever altitudinal recording of a tiger. In 2019, the Kedarnath wildlife sanctuary (Chamoli, Uttarakhand) sighted a tigress at 11,155 feet; another striped big cat was seen in the Askot Musk Sanctuary (Pithoragarh, Uttarakhand) at 10,000 feet in 2016.

The time stamp on the camera trap says May 2025, but it was processed only recently. While the sighting is a natural history landmark, it doesn't on its own suggest tigers are permanently adapting to high-altitude Himalayan zones or making the region a permanent territory. But it does challenge long-held assumptions about the 'altitudinal limits' of tiger ecology.

The sighting underscores that Himalayan eco-corridors may be more functionally connected than believed. This offers hope that tigers could expand their range into mountainous regions, enhancing genetic exchange and adaptive resilience. The sighting is also a cue for conservationists and policymakers to include alpine and sub-alpine forests in long-term wildlife protection plans.